

an e-mail message except that the target username is specified rather than an e-mail address. Like e-mail, private messages can be sent to a number of users at once; however most social networking sites place some restrictions on the total number of people to whom a single private message can be sent. Unlike e-mail, no attachments can normally be sent with a private message. E-mail messages can also be sent, but many sites keep their users' e-mail details secret, and messages are then sent via a web based form where the e-mail address is not displayed. On some sites, users can choose whether to make their e-mail address publicly viewable or not. There may also be restrictions on contacting members (by PM or e-mail) who are greater than a certain number of degrees away. This can be a site-wide setting or a degree number specified by a user in their profile.

Some sites store profile information on user's instant messaging (IM) or short message service (SMS) accounts, but do not normally provide any inbuilt functionality to send messages using these services, rather linking to external sites or resources that can provide this functionality. Another method of user to user communication is the virtual card or vCard. vCards allow the automatic exchange of information typically found on a traditional business card. vCards are not limited to text however, and can include photos, company logos, hyperlinks, etc.

## **Community Discussion**

The community discussion forum has been a popular feature of Internet-based communication since the early days of mailing lists and USENET newsgroups. It has evolved beyond a static admin-maintained bulletin board into the realm of social networking, where communities can be created by any user (as on orkut and Tribe) and will live or die depending on whether they reach a certain critical momentum. The creator of a forum usually acts as the moderator, pruning undesirable threads and banning unwanted users from the forum. Community forums are classified in categories according to major social or professional topics, depending on the type of parent site. They may also integrate event meeting